What it Means to Be a Man – Collection 1

By Rudyard Kipling, Charles Bukowski, John Struloeff and Harold Norse

INTRODUCTION

Fathers can be many things: involved, absent, loving, abusive, supportive or controlling. In some cases, they can be all of the above. But one thing is certain, their influence impacts their sons positively or negatively in profound ways. Fathers can determine the type of man their sons ultimately become – be it through words of advice, the daily examples they set, or even through their absence. Yes, some sons are left to figure things out for themselves. But whatever your experience with your father has been like – positive, negative, or a mix of both – there's always a choice moving forward. What kind of lessons will you teach the next generation of sons about What it Means to Be a Man?

What it Means to Be a Man – A Collection with poems by Rudyard Kipling, Charles Bukowski, John Struloeff and Harold Norse

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If by Rudyard Kipling

If you can keep your head when all about you
Are losing theirs and blaming it on you;
If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,
But make allowance for their doubting too;
If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,
Or, being lied about, don't deal in lies,
Or, being hated, don't give way to hating,
And yet don't look too good, nor talk too wise;

If you can dream - and not make dreams your master;
If you can think - and not make thoughts your aim;
If you can meet with triumph and disaster
And treat those two imposters just the same;
If you can bear to hear the truth you've spoken
Twisted by knaves to make a trap for fools,
Or watch the things you gave your life to broken,
And stoop and build 'em up with worn out tools;

If you can make one heap of all your winnings
And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
And lose, and start again at your beginnings

And never breath a word about your loss;
If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew
To serve your turn long after they are gone,
And so hold on when there is nothing in you
Except the Will which says to them: "Hold on";
If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
Or walk with kings - nor lose the common touch;
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you;
If all men count with you, but none too much;
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
With sixty seconds' worth of distance run -
Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it,
And - which is more - you'll be a Man my son!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rudyard Kipling
Book: If: A Father's Advice to His Son
ISBN: 978-0689877995
Publisher: Simon and Schuster
Date (Month/Year): 2007

AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier – Kipling poem only

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My Father by Charles Bukowski (Pg 283-284)

(My father) was a truly amazing man
he pretended to be
rich
even though we lived on beans and mush and weenies
when we sat down to eat, he said,
"not everybody can eat like this."

and because he wanted to be rich or because he actually
thought he was rich
he always voted Republican
and he voted for Hoover against Roosevelt
and he lost
and then he voted for Alf Landon against Roosevelt
and he lost again
saying, "I don't know what this world is coming to,
now we've got that god damned Red in there again
and the Russians will be in our backyard next!"

I think it was my father who made me decide to
become a bum.
I decided that if a man like that wants to be rich

then I want to be poor.

and I became a bum.
I lived on nickels and dimes and in cheap rooms and
on park benches.
I thought maybe the bums knew something.

but I found out that most of the bums wanted to be
rich too.
they had just failed at that.

so caught between my father and the bums
I had no place to go
and I went there fast and slow.
never voted Republican
never voted.

buried him
like an oddity of the earth
like a hundred thousand oddities
like millions of other oddities,
wasted.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:** Charles Bukowski*
***Book:** Septuagenarian Stew: Stories and Poems, (Pg 283-284)*
***ISBN:** 978-0876857946*
***Publisher:** Black Sparrow Press*
***Date (Month/Year):** May 2002*

The Man I Was Supposed to Be by John Struloeff (Part II)

The man I was supposed to be works
in a small cedar mill in Oregon.
The heel of his left boot is worn smooth
by the way the engage lever makes him stand,
the shift he has to make, grinding his heel,
a slow turn as the log carriage feeds the wood
that will shriek against the rolling blade.
He watches the blade eight hours a day,
and when he goes home to sleep,
he sees the blade rolling in the dark.

The man I was supposed to be has two sons,
and when his youngest is loud he twists his ear,
watching for the boy's eyes to well with tears.

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Knock off the racket, he says. The TV's on.
If the boy does it again, he grabs him by his hair,
drags him to his room, then watches TV in silence,
the way it is supposed to be.

The man I was supposed to be buys beer in a case
and drives around at night, looking for a friend
to drink it with. He drinks until his face is numb
and awakens on the cement floor of his garage,
lying flat on his back, his arms spread.
Both of his hands are bleeding.

The man I was supposed to be tracks deer
on the leaf-covered trails behind his house.
There is a doe ahead of him somewhere,
and he kneels to place his fingertips on its tracks.
That night he will smell the rawness of warm bone
and blood. It will hang in his garage seven days
until he begins to separate the loosened joints
and carefully strip the flesh. He will do it alone,
at night, his forearms and hands coated in blood.

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Like the stink of beer-sweat and fresh cedar dust,
this odor will stay in his skin for days.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John Struloeff
ISBN: 978-0931507212
Publisher: Loom Press
Date (Month/Year): March 2008

I am Not a Man by Harold Norse (Pg 133)

I am not a man, I can't earn a living, buy things for my family.
I am not a man, I don't like football, boxing and cars.
I like to express my feelings,
and I even like to put an arm around my friends shoulders.
I am not a man, I won't play the role assigned to me.
The role created by Madison Avenue, *Playboy*, Hollywood,
and Oliver Cromwell. Television does not dictate my behavior.
I am not a man, once when I shot a squirrel, I swore I would never kill again.
I gave up meat, the sight of blood makes me sick.
I like flowers.

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I do not fight back when real men beat me up or call me queer.

I dislike violence.

I don't get emotional when a flag is waved.

I do not think I should love America or leave it, I think I should laugh at it.

I am not a man. *Playboy* is not my favorite magazine.

I am not a man. I cry when I am unhappy.

I am not a man. I do not feel superior to women.

I am not a man. I write poetry.

I am not a man. I meditate on peace and love.

I am not a man. I do not want to destroy you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Harold Norse
Book: The Outlaw Bible of American Poetry, Pg 133
ISBN: 978-1560252276
Publisher: Thunder's Mouth Press
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1999

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2005 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2009 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2010 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
(Combined with Logic In the House of Sawed-Off Telescopes by Jeffrey McDaniel (Pg 253) and I'm an Emotional Idiot by Maggie Estep (Pg 256) -- The Outlaw Bible of American Poetry)

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